

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 9 · 11 September 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

bubbletea.nz · est. 2026



BREAKING · FENWICK GROVE

Hand-Knitted Letterbox Cozies Reach Sixth Property, Risk Assessed Low

Case definition: any letterbox fitted with a knitted woollen cover, ribbed or cabled, colour-matched to its house numbers. Six confirmed properties as of Tuesday, up from two after the Kowhai Grove Knitting Circle began "finishing what winter started." The street's group chat has requested "a colour roster," stopping short of an actual pattern-sharing mandate.

Community Outbreak Bulletin

TECHNOLOGY · PRODUCT

One More Thing: The Lid Click

Steve Jobs

"We re-engineered the click. Fourteen milliseconds shorter, and it's a different pitch entirely — a full semitone higher. This isn't a lid. This is confirmation."

POLITICS · DISPATCH

On the Matter of the Footpath

Richard Nixon

"The council will tell you the footpath resurfacing is on schedule. I have found, in my experience, that anything described as 'on schedule' by the people who set the schedule deserves a second look."



BUSINESS · MARKETS

A Position, Held Precisely As Long As Necessary

Held the Nordholm twenty-years through the entire morning print run, out at the close, to the tick. Nine points, clean. Judy asked what I was celebrating. I told her: nothing. That's the part she never understood.

Sherman McCoy

MUSIC · REVIEW

Nothing To Prove, Everything To Say

Rebecca Black

On "Low Tide, Late" by Marion Vale: no hook chasing you down, no chorus performing a certainty it hasn't earned. Just a voice that's clearly lived through the thing it's singing about, unhurried enough to let the silence between verses actually mean something.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA · DID YOU KNOW?

Two Pearls, Two Entirely Different Chemistries

Classic tapioca pearls are cooked starch; "popping boba" is a completely different technology — a thin gel skin formed by dripping fruit juice into a calcium bath, the same spherification trick used in cocktail garnishes, repurposed for a straw.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"Nine points, clean. That's the part she never understood."

— Sherman McCoy, on knowing exactly when to let go

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why did the bubble tea file a police report? It got mugged.

Overload NZ 2026

26–27 Sept · NZ International Convention Centre. Cosplay, artists & guests incl. Ladybeard, Chelsey Furedi & Rin Sakura. Tickets: overload.co.nz — about two weeks out now.



TRAVEL · VACATION LOG, DAY 14

Like, We Just Wanted To See One (1) Waterfall, Man

Hiked forty minutes to the lookout, and there's a guy in a rain-cape mask standing right where the track splits, going "turn back." Scoob says "Rhaterfall?" and I'm like, buddy, that's the whole itinerary. Turned out to be the campground owner, diverting hikers around a wasps' nest he hadn't gotten around to reporting. Free hot chips for the detour, though. Worth it. Mostly.

Shaggy Rogers (& Scooby-Doo)

SPORT · RECAP (ILLUSTRATIVE)

He Slowed Down Four Strides Before Anyone Else Noticed

T. Marlow, Sports Desk

Runner "K. Emerson" led the whole back straight, comfortable, textbook — until his arm carriage tightened up a half-stride early, the tell of a pace he hadn't actually banked for. I'd seen it a full turn back. Everyone else saw it at the line.

MARKETS · THE PEARL INDEX

Umbrella Correlation, Statistically Real, Practically Useless

Priya Anand, The Pearl Index

Fielded against n=380 this fortnight: on days with rain before 9am, average order size is up 11% (±3.9% MOE). Whether that's comfort-drinking or just more people already indoors near a counter, the data cannot say — and I'd be lying if I claimed I wasn't personally a contributing data point three times this week.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Loyalty Card Check

Last week's Correlation Desk, resolved: with Kelburn ruled out of first and Birchfield needing to sit immediately above Ashgrove, only one order survives — Birchfield first, Ashgrove second, Kelburn third.

Three regulars' loyalty cards, checked at closing:

- 1. Talia has more stamps than whoever ordered the jasmine.
- 2. Rowan's card doesn't show nine stamps.
- 3. The brown sugar drinker's card shows exactly seven stamps.

Brisk warm-up · which drink does Rowan actually order? Answer next week — Ken Endo

Route 9 Motors — Winter Clearance

"You don't test-drive this lot. You qualify for it." — Lewis Hamilton

Zero-deposit finance, this week only.

IN MEMORIAM

The Loyalty Card, Ninth Stamp Never Reached

Skeletor

It lived a full seven weeks in a wallet, dutifully stamped, one square shy of a free drink, before its owner switched allegiances to a shop two doors down over a shorter queue. I am told this happens constantly and nobody mourns it. I mourn it. Someone must. Filed, alongside the free drink that will now never be redeemed.

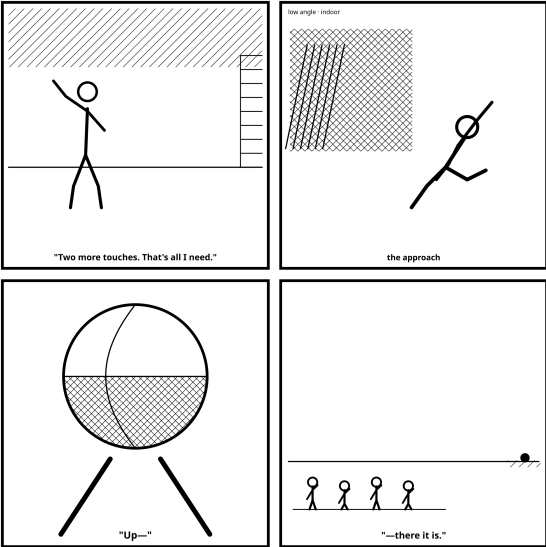
ASK THE CAPTAIN

Adrift Near the Counter

Horatio McCallister

"I've been getting coffee at the same café for months hoping to work up the nerve to ask the barista out. Any advice?" Adrift near the counter, ye've been circlin' the same buoy for months — a ship that only ever passes by never gets boarded. Order somethin' different next time, and ask a question that isn't about the menu. Fair winds.

HAYAKU · DEBUT



Hayaku — an original senkotsu-style strip, Bubble Tea News's new syndicated cartoon slot, hand-authored SVG rendered via Inkscape